art—ready-made or found object, intervention, documentation, and word-based—which artists take on singularly or in tandem. In Berlin, the physical and symbolic contours of the city compelled conceptual artists in all four of Godfrey's registers, as they set sights on the strata and stories of Germany's division, as well as previous eras of conflict laid bare in the city. The Wall was alternately considered a ready-made, a revised object, a site of beckoned interactivity, an observation tool, and a structure inviting cultural dialogue.

The range of opportunities for exploration often occurred with the financial and programmatic assistance of state-sponsored or mainstream American and German institutions. An anchor of this scene was one of its chief sponsors, the Deutscher Akademischer Austauschdienst (German Academic Exchange Service), or DAAD, which supported a steady rotation of international artists' projects in Berlin each year, including many proposed by Americans. The DAAD's artist program was originally funded in 1963 with a three-year, $3-million grant from the Ford Foundation and was later operated with support from the Berlin senate and the German government. Grantees were not limited to visual art but ranged in discipline from literature to performance. Among the first grantees were abstract painter Shirley Jaffe and poet W. H. Auden, a then-recent transplant to the United States from England. In West Berlin, a range of cultural institutions became venues with which the DAAD artists routinely showed and collaborated. The Free University, which opened in 1948, routinely hosted visiting scholars and in 1963 inaugurated its John F. Kennedy Institute for North American Studies. The Goethe-Institut also adjusted its outlook and methods across its network of language schools to include cultural programming appropriate to a time of dissent. Despite these larger, significant supports, other artists chose to break from the rhythms and constraints of grant cycles. The Galerie René Block began hosting visiting artist shows and performances in 1964, in coordination with the DAAD. Smaller grassroots organizations such as Künstlerhaus Bethanien, which fully opened in 1974 in an abandoned hospital in Kreuzberg, provided workspaces and residencies to international artists, including those from the United States. Overall, subsidized and supported artistic exchanges between Americans and West Germans were increasingly available to those seeking outlets in West Berlin through official networks. Such programs incubated a culture of experimentation and critique in proximity to the Wall.